

Chapter 36-2: Heartless Person

When she got close, Ning Fuyi understood why there was no one around. The cold air emanating from Chu Qingqiu was simply too intense, like a summer ice cellar for storing melons and fruits - just getting one step closer brought chilling coldness.

Even Qiu Yi wasn't guarding nearby, having been sent away to who knows where by Chu Qingqiu. Ning Fuyi approached behind Chu Qingqiu with her hands behind her back. Just as she was about to speak, a plate suddenly flew up from the table, spinning toward her forehead as if intending to slice off her skull.

Fortunately, Ning Fuyi was quick-eyed and nimble, dodging to the side. The plate flew right into the head of an unfortunate drunk immortal who happened to be passing by. With a "thud," the unlucky person fell backward unconscious.

Soon two small immortal attendants came walking on short legs, carrying the drunk immortal away to rest.

"Who goes there..." Chu Qingqiu looked up coldly, but when she saw clearly that it was Ning Fuyi, her words stopped abruptly, though the cold air around her became even heavier.

"What are you here for?" she said, raising her fingertip. The wine pot on the table automatically flew up and poured wine for her.

How would I know what I came for? Ning Fuyi thought to herself. She smiled awkwardly and sat down cross-legged beside her.

Although Chu Qingqiu's anger grew even stronger, fortunately she didn't drive her away. Instead, she tilted her head back and poured the wine into her mouth. A crystal drop of wine flowed down her beautifully contoured chin, flowing into her chest that was covered by layers of clothing.

Ning Fuyi looked away.

"Is the Divine Venerable drowning her sorrows in alcohol because of what happened during the day?" Ning Fuyi glanced at the wine cup on her table.

"It has nothing to do with you. Get lost quickly." Chu Qingqiu said in a low voice, raising her hand to pour more wine.

If it had nothing to do with her, why such a big reaction upon seeing her? Ning Fuyi thought, then spoke aloud: "Divine Venerable, rest assured. Although I'm not exactly a good person, I've never liked spreading gossip. I absolutely won't reveal even half a word about what I saw in the illusion."

"If the Divine Venerable doesn't believe me, I'll swear an oath right now." She raised her hand as she spoke, but was slapped back onto the table by a gust of air from Chu Qingqiu.

"No need. If you really say even one word, I'll naturally pull out your tongue." Chu Qingqiu said flatly.

How fierce. Ning Fuyi closed her mouth.

Having said this much, she should have left, but Ning Fuyi somehow couldn't move her feet. So she spoke to console her: "Since it's in the past, the Divine Venerable can forget it. Who doesn't have a past in life?"

"Who says I still remember?" Chu Qingqiu said.

Then what are you being sad about? Ning Fuyi thought.

"After all, that person has long forgotten about it too." Chu Qingqiu seemed drunk and actually said one more sentence, then swallowed more wine.

So it was a faithless, ungrateful wretch who obtained her and then abandoned her. No wonder Chu Qingqiu became the way she is today. No wonder she went to cultivate the Path of Emotionlessness - she had suffered such deep emotional wounds.

"Since she's scum, you shouldn't hurt yourself over it even more." Ning Fuyi spoke up. "Since she betrayed you, you should go back and find her to beat her up once or twice, resolve the obsession in your heart. If she really hurt you deeply, tie her up and feed her to Bai Lin¹, ridding the world of one more menace."

Chu Qingqiu's hand holding the wine cup paused, and the cold air around her lessened slightly.

"You really understand holding grudges and seeking revenge." After a long while, she finally spoke, her tone no longer so cold.

Seeing that her consolation was effective, Ning Fuyi was quite pleased and didn't stay longer, getting up and saying: "This disciple takes her leave."

Chu Qingqiu hummed in response, but suddenly called out to stop her as Ning Fuyi was turning around, not looking at her but raising one arm.

Ning Fuyi didn't understand what she meant, looking at her hand, then at her profile.

"Take this." Chu Qingqiu said, shaking her sleeve to reveal a dark One-Thought Pearl² strung with red cord on her wrist.

"A One-Thought Pearl?" Ning Fuyi was very surprised. She knew this thing was said to be able to store all things, difficult to find throughout the six realms. In her previous life, she had only seen her own one.

And that one didn't know where it came from - it just suddenly appeared on her wrist one day and couldn't be removed no matter what.

She reached out her hand and untied it from Chu Qingqiu's delicate wrist, but deliberately avoided any possibility of contact with her, causing her to struggle for quite a while before the heavy pearl finally fell into her palm.

"Is the Divine Venerable giving this to me?" she asked in surprise.

"This originally belonged to your mother. It should rightfully be returned to you." Chu Qingqiu said, then continued drinking without talking to Ning Fuyi anymore.

Miraculously, when the thing fell into Ning Fuyi's hands, it seemed to take root, firmly fixing itself to her wrist.

A familiar feeling struck her. Could it be that the One-Thought Pearl from her previous life was this very one?

She thanked Chu Qingqiu and turned to leave Seven Absolutes Hall. When the cool wind of the divine mountain blew on her face, Ning Fuyi suddenly experienced a feeling she had never had before.

This lifetime's Chu Qingqiu, aside from still having a bad temper, actually wasn't so hateful.

When the first ray of dawn light appeared in the east, the Zhaoyang Conference began amid the chorus of a hundred birds on the divine mountain.

The sect leaders of the six major sects stood in a circle at Zhaoyang Peak. Different colored lights burst forth from their palms, gathering at the center into a pillar of light that shot straight toward the not-yet-bright sky. The dazzling light suddenly spread out, complementing the half-round sun emerging from the east, momentarily brighter than daylight itself.

This opened the Chaotic Realm³. A huge white circle appeared in the sky directly above, and the disciples who had been standing on the high platform all transformed into points of starlight, flowing into the white circle.

The scene was extremely spectacular for a moment. Everyone seemed to fall into the Milky Way, with rising points of light leaving afterimages in mid-air, like luminous pillars reaching to the sky.

After all disciples entered the Chaotic Realm, the light pillar finally dimmed. The seven sect leaders of the six major sects lowered their hands, and the remaining wind made their robes flutter in the air.

"The previous Zhaoyang Conferences were all won by disciples of Tianji Sword Sect. This time will probably be no exception. Tianji Sword Sect truly deserves to be the first sect, admirable." The sect leader of Kongming Sect⁴, the last of the six sects, Master Feiguang⁵, smiled as he spoke.

The sect leader and disciples of Kongming Sect were all bald monks. Master Feiguang was especially a fat monk with a shiny bald head who looked very amiable when he smiled.

"Not at all, not at all. Each generation produces new talents. I see that this time there are quite a few new faces among the disciples who came to Zhaoyang. It will probably be hard to determine the winner." Tang Wenshu⁶ smiled elegantly, gesturing for the other sect leaders to return to the high platform and take their seats.

After the disciples all entered the Chaotic Realm, Zhaoyang Peak was no longer lively but became much more solemn, with only the sect leaders and elders of each sect, plus scattered disciples who had given up participating, still sitting on the high platform.

Before the sect leaders could chat for more than a few words, several disciples suddenly fell from the sky, without exception landing on their buttocks. The white-bearded old man waved his brush, and the names of eliminated disciples and their sects were written in ink in mid-air. The sect leaders whose names were mentioned all blushed, and some who couldn't bear it had already started scolding the disciples who had been eliminated right after entering.

"Everyone, don't be anxious. The trials are full of dangers, and occasional eliminations are nothing. Only those who remain to the end can determine victory and defeat." The white-bearded old man chuckled, waving his brush again. Yesterday's rainbow-like arched door appeared again, divided into small sections showing the situation inside the Chaotic Realm.

"I wonder if those two Northern Garden disciples from our sect can survive the first trial." Elder Pingyao looked at the arched door searching for his own disciples' figures, saying worriedly.

"That Liu Wenzhu is the eldest daughter of the Liu family, intelligent and talented, with divine power at her side. She probably won't be too bad. It's just that Ning Fuyi..." Elder Jingshan laughed. "I only hope she can hold on a bit longer and not embarrass our Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate too much."

Chu Qingqiu didn't listen to their words but looked at the arched door in front of her as if in meditation.

At the same time, inside the Chaotic Realm.

Ning Fuyi had landed together with other disciples from Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate. She almost fell when she landed, fortunately Liu Wenzhu and Rong Jin landed beside her at the same time, grabbing her arms and pulling her up.

"Thank you." Ning Fuyi said, then surveyed the surroundings.

She saw that this place seemed to be a dense forest. The trees around them were all strange and bizarre shapes - some towering into the clouds, some with vines piled like waterfalls, and some actually growing upside down with their tops buried in the soil.

"Isn't this Tongchuan?" Feng Ge, who had landed nearby, drew her spiritual sword and pushed aside the waist-high shrubs in front of her.

"It is Tongchuan." Hong Ying⁸, the managing disciple of the Eastern Garden, said in a deep voice. He took the heavy sword from his back and held it in front of his chest. "Everyone from Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, stay close to me. Tongchuan is dangerous - be careful not to fall behind."

As soon as he finished speaking, a scroll fell from the sky into his hands.

"It says this trial is about dealing with spirit beasts. Within two hours, whoever obtains the most beast stones⁹ from spirit beasts wins." Hong Ying loudly relayed what was written on the scroll.

Although everything in the Chaotic Realm was real, it was all illusory, so the hunted spirit beasts weren't real. But it was equally dangerous.

"Let's go." Hong Ying said roughly, leading everyone forward, but was suddenly stopped by Feng Ge.

"Wait." Feng Ge pointed behind Hong Ying at Ning Fuyi, who was preparing to follow, her eyes showing some impatience. "Do we really have to bring her?"

"Senior Sister Feng Ge, what do you mean by that? Fuyi is also one of our Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate people. How can there be any reason not to bring her!" Even the usually good-tempered Rong Jin couldn't help it and spoke up.

"Why?" Feng Ge frowned. "This is the border of Tongchuan, with low-level spirit beasts. The deeper we go, the more high-level spirit beasts there will be, and we might even encounter demonic beasts. With her low cultivation, staying here would actually be safer."

"Since we want Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate to win, we need to hunt more spirit beasts to get more crystals. Liu Wenzhu is one thing, but with her Mortal Realm cultivation following us, we'll not only have to hunt spirit beasts but also constantly protect her. Wouldn't that drag down all of us?"

Ning Fuyi had long heard her meaning and didn't argue back. Instead, she crossed her arms and leaned against a tree trunk, listening lazily.

"Senior Sister doesn't need to worry. Wenzhu and I will protect her ourselves." Rong Jin's usually smiling face was full of anger.

"You protect her?" Feng Ge hugged her sword and snorted. "Do you know how dangerous the depths of Tongchuan are? When the time comes, you won't even be able to protect yourselves, and you still want to protect her?"

Just as Rong Jin was about to say something more, another male disciple from the Western Garden spoke up: "I think Senior Sister makes sense. Her following would not only be dangerous but also cause unnecessary trouble."

Two others also agreed, and Hong Ying fell into troubled contemplation.

After a long while, he finally nodded and turned to Ning Fuyi: "Fine, your cultivation is indeed difficult to survive with. Just stay here and wait."

However, contrary to his expectations, Ning Fuyi showed no panic or sadness. Instead, she continued leaning lazily against the tree trunk and waved at them quite happily.

"Take care, no need to see you off." She smiled.

Author's Note: Ning Fuyi: Hehe, guess what? I'm insulting myself!

Footnotes:

1. **Bai Lin (白麟)** - Chu Qingqiu's white tiger/qilin companion
2. **One-Thought Pearl (一念珠)** - A magical storage device that can contain many items in a small space
3. **Chaotic Realm (混沌境)** - A mystical dimension created for the competition trials
4. **Kongming Sect (空明宗)** - "Empty Brightness Sect," one of the six major sects, composed of Buddhist monks
5. **Master Feiguang (飞光禅师)** - "Flying Light Zen Master," the sect leader of Kongming Sect
6. **Tang Wenshu (唐温书)** - The sect leader of Tianji Sword Sect
7. **Tongchuan (铜川)** - A dangerous area known for its spirit beasts and hazards
8. **Hong Ying (洪影)** - A senior disciple from Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate's Eastern Garden
9. **Beast stones (兽石)** - Magical crystals found within spirit beasts, used as proof of successful hunting